

Chapter Title: Goldberg Variations, BWV 988

Chapter Author(s): JOHANN SEBASTIAN BACH

Book Title: The Piano

Book Subtitle: A History in 100 Pieces

Book Author(s): Susan Tomes

Published by: Yale University Press. (2021)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv1t1kfj8.5>

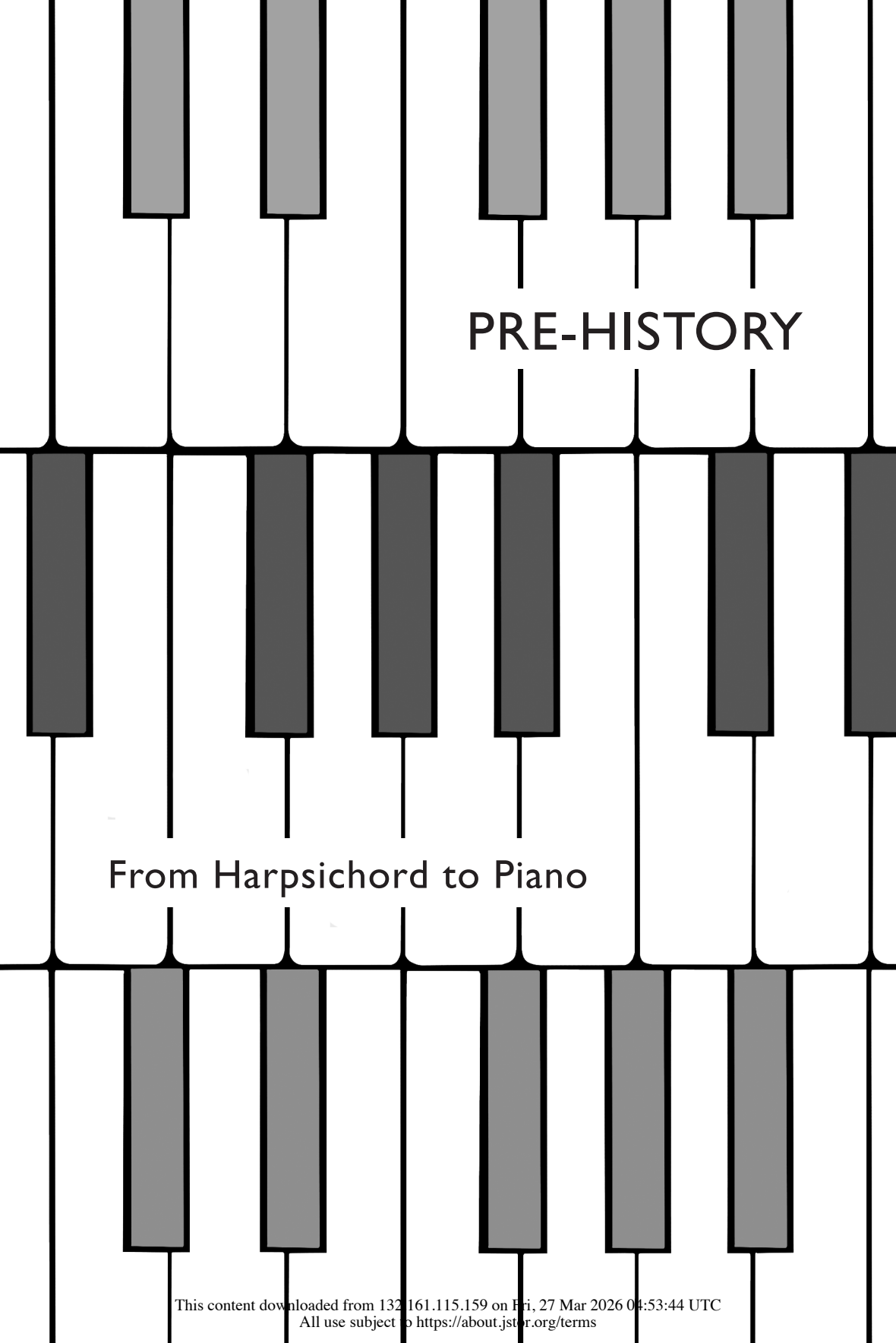
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PRE-HISTORY

From Harpsichord to Piano

JOHANN SEBASTIAN BACH (1685–1750)

I. *Goldberg Variations*, BWV 988

In choosing 100 pieces of piano music, I'm aware that I could use up nearly all my selections on the keyboard works of Johann Sebastian Bach. Just his 48 Preludes and Fugues (*The Well-Tempered Clavier*, two sets of 24 preludes and fugues, published respectively in 1722 and 1742) could take up almost half of my choices straightaway, and by adding some Inventions, Partitas, English Suites, French Suites, concertos, duo sonatas and transcriptions one could more or less use up the full hundred. There might be some justification for this, because J.S. Bach is still, after 300 years, at the top of most people's choice of Great Composers.

What is so special about Bach? His mastery of compositional forms and styles, his intellectual energy, his integrity, his sincerity and the consistently high quality of his work are all admirable. Bach came at the end of a period in which the *craft* of music, rather than the personality of the composer, was considered of prime importance. Shortly after Bach's time, the emphasis moved to the *drama* of the composer's feelings, the sense that composers can give us of their grappling with fate and individual experience. Craft remained essential, of course, but by Beethoven's time the element of drama had come to the forefront, whereas in Bach's music, craft is still paramount. His keyboard works are a testament to this kind of craft, the result of hard intellectual work over many years combined with a keyboard player's love and understanding of what's involved in playing an instrument.

It should perhaps be admitted that many young pianists only know Bach through his keyboard music and have not yet had a chance to encounter the large-scale dramatic works on religious texts – the *St Matthew Passion*, the *St John Passion*, the *B minor Mass*, and the rich cycle of church Cantatas which gave Bach the opportunity to display to the full his insight into human nature. His keyboard works, however, are not based on texts and have no words or obvious story. For young pianists, this can make the study of Bach a little dry. Bach was keenly interested in the art of combining different musical lines so that they work wonderfully

together without any line having to sacrifice any portion of content or detail. This makes his keyboard writing very 'busy'; often there are two, three, even four lines active at the same time, all with melodies to make smooth, and complicated fingering to attend to. The rhythms are often quite straightforward, but the rhythmic activity is lively and constant.

In Mozart's writing, by contrast, there is often an intricate melodic line in the right hand while the left plays a simpler bass line. Bach rarely does this. In fact, he seems to make a point of giving every line of counterpoint an equal share of activity, almost as if it were a moral principle to do so. For the player, this demands a constant attention – there is hardly a moment when one can coast along, taking one's eyes off the detail, for there is always something happening in one line or another, often in several lines simultaneously, and the interweaving of strands calls for ingenious fingering patterns. As a young pianist myself I remember finding this laborious. At that stage I had only come across some preludes and fugues, and a few Inventions. It was much later that I encountered Bach's orchestral and choral music, and when I had taken in its splendid architecture and emotional sweep I then realised that I could hear echoes of it in the keyboard music, which made me want to explore more of that music.

Bach's life and the emergence of the piano only overlapped slightly – the piano did not start to be developed until he was already a mature composer. His main instruments were the harpsichord and organ; when Bach used the word 'clavier' he probably meant a range of keyboard instruments including harpsichord and clavichord, and sometimes such music was suitable for the organ too. Bach would have played a range of harpsichords, some with one keyboard or 'manual', some with two. The sound was made by a plectrum plucking the string. This made the sound of the harpsichord distinctly different from that of the piano, where a small rounded hammer-head strikes the string from below. In the early days of the piano, there was not much difference between the carrying power of the piano and that of the harpsichord, but the piano gave the player more control over the volume of each note, which opened up more expressive possibilities.

As far as we know, Bach encountered the piano round about 1736, when he was already fifty. In imitation of the Italian inventor Bartolomeo Cristofori who first developed a prototype of the modern piano in the 1720s, the Dresden instrument maker Gottfried Silbermann had built a piano, which Bach was asked to try. Bach admired the tone but found that it was too weak in the high register, and too hard to play. Silbermann was disappointed, but eventually set about making improvements. There is a gap in our knowledge of Bach's acquaintance with pianos until 1747 when he went to Berlin to visit his son Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach, then the official harpsichordist at the court of Frederick the Great of Prussia. Frederick had bought a number of recent pianos made by Silbermann and J.S. Bach was again asked to try them. Legend has it that the king himself composed a very complicated theme and asked Bach to improvise upon it (although some historians have thought it more likely that C.P.E. Bach, at his majesty's request, supplied the theme and took some delight in devising something complicated enough to test his father's famous powers of invention). At any rate, this theme later became the basis for J.S. Bach's *Musical Offering*, the gigantic collection of fugues and canons which he composed in his last decade. By then Bach was more focused on the art and craft of composition than on the particular instruments which would play his music, and we do not know whether his encounters with Silbermann's pianos were of lasting significance to him.

Although Bach's harpsichord music continues to be played and appreciated on the harpsichord, pianists have always claimed that his music sounds just as good if not better on the modern piano. Many believe that if the modern piano had been around in Bach's time he would have liked hearing his music played on it, and might have written new music to play to its strengths (for example, experimenting with the sustaining pedal, which his harpsichord lacked). We know that Bach, like many composers of his age, was open-minded about exactly what instrument was used, and famously some of his works (for example *The Art of Fugue*) don't specify the instrumentation. Nevertheless he was a practical person; his keyboard music was written for the instruments he knew, not for some imagined future development of them. We might guess that he would welcome the sound of his *Goldberg Variations* on the modern piano, and so he might, but the question must remain open.

It's important that today's pianists should have an idea of what the harpsichord sounded like, so that they can factor it into their decisions about how to play Bach's music. For example, many pianists routinely use the sustaining pedal to create the illusion of 'legato', the smooth linking of one note to another. This was not an option on the harpsichord, where legato had to be created by finger-work alone, one finger not leaving a note until the next finger has gone down on the next note. The resulting sound, dry but smooth, is very different from the legato we customarily hear in today's piano music and is a sonority worth learning to create.

The argument for playing Bach on the piano received a boost in 1955 when the Canadian pianist Glenn Gould recorded the *Goldberg Variations*. At the time, the piece was not part of standard piano repertoire and was considered the specialist preserve of harpsichordists like Wanda Landowska. Gould (then only twenty-two) persuaded his record company to let him try his hand(s) at the *Goldberg Variations* on a Steinway piano. The result made his name and set many pianists scrambling to bring Bach's music into the fold. Gould had a brilliant mind and a wonderfully nimble technique and clarity of articulation, made even clearer by the rather dry, close recording on which he insisted. He was keenly interested in the editing process, and the result is a rare amalgam of old music sounding sparkingly new on a modern instrument. (He recorded the *Goldberg Variations* a second time in 1981, and that version also has many fans.) Following his example, pianists everywhere descended confidently upon Bach's keyboard works and snatched them up for recital programmes. At the time of writing there is a healthy spread of approaches to Bach's keyboard music, from historically aware performances on harpsichord to piano interpretations using all the resources of the modern instrument, jazzed-up versions with drums and bass, and performances on accordion, electronic synthesiser and digital pianos.

Let us stay with the *Goldberg Variations* to consider why they have become a staple of modern piano recital repertoire. Their origin is one of the more charming legends of music history. Bach had an occasional pupil, Johann Goldberg, who was in the service of Count Kaiserling, the former Russian ambassador to the court of Saxony. Count Kaiserling was troubled with insomnia and used to

summon Goldberg to play the harpsichord to him when he couldn't sleep at night. The Count mentioned to Bach that he would like some new and restful pieces which Goldberg could play to him. Bach's response was to compose a grand set of thirty variations on an 'Aria' which appears at the beginning and end of the set. How much of this story is true, we are not sure. Bach was not in the habit of writing sets of variations, and even after writing this magnificent set he didn't adopt the habit. It's possible he was just taken with the idea on the spur of the moment, or perhaps Goldberg suggested something interesting enough to keep himself awake when he had to get up in the night to play harpsichord music to his employer. Goldberg himself appears only to have been a teenager at the time. But of course teenagers can be brilliant players, so Goldberg's age doesn't rule out the truth of the story. At any rate, Bach composed a real *tour de force*, almost a compendium of keyboard styles from the graceful melodic sarabande which forms the 'Aria' to the rapid acrobatics of the fastest variations.

The structure of the work is ingenious. All the variations are based not on the melody but on the simple 32-bar harmonic progression we hear in the bass of the Aria; these take the eight-bar phrases to cadences (resting points) in G, D, E minor and G. The melody of the Aria is, however, memorable. Its principal features are graceful downward-drooping phrases. Although the bass line proceeds in units of eight bars, the melody divides into units of four bars, so that each bass line unit has a pair of melodic phrases above it. This remains the case until the last eight-bar unit, where suddenly the right hand has a continuous eight-bar melodic line as well. Most of it is in running semiquavers, which gives the effect of the music gathering energy towards the end. Bach was particularly skilled at this effect, a sort of musical friction derived from something which seems to be speeding up as something else winds down to a close.

After the Aria and Variations 1 and 2, Bach embarks on a pattern of variations grouped in threes. At the start of every group there is a canon (a melody followed at a given distance by an imitative melody). The first canon is 'at the unison', meaning that the imitative melody is at the same pitch as the model melody. The second canon (three variations later) is 'at the second', meaning that the imitation occurs a note higher than the model. And so on: the third canon is 'at the third',

the fourth 'at the fourth', all the way to Variation 27 which is 'at the ninth'. This set of canons alone is an impressive achievement.

In each group of three variations, the middle variation is of independent character. In these 'middle pieces' we encounter various Baroque dances, a fughetta (a little fugue), an 'overture' with stately dotted rhythms in the French style, and two of the loveliest pieces in this or any other composition, Variation 13 in G major and Variation 25 in G minor – both of them featuring intricate lyrical melodic lines, like the passionate violin solo 'Erbarne dich, mein Gott' which is a high point of the *St Matthew Passion*. And in each group, the third item is a brilliant piece of writing to be played on the two harpsichord manuals, keyboards one above and behind the other on the same instrument, allowing for different sonorities to be contrasted and enabling the hands to cross without hitting each other. This group of variations naturally causes the most technical difficulty on the modern piano with its single keyboard, for the pianist's hands must often compete for space when crossing over one another. So Bach's design gives us nine groups of three variations, each beginning with a canon and ending with a display of brilliant fingerwork. This takes us up to the joyfully clattering Variation 29.

Variation 30 is a 'Quodlibet', a form well known in the Bach family with its many musicians; at the end of family gatherings they would have fun playing and improvising on whatever instruments they had, often incorporating folk songs. In this cheery variation, Bach reveals nothing about what he might be quoting, but scholars have identified at least two earthy songs which are woven into the melody line. 'I haven't been with you for so long' is one, and 'Cabbage and turnips have driven me away' is another. Many have found it surprising that Bach decided to end such a complex and dignified structure with folk song, but there is something grounding about it too. After this, Bach simply writes: 'Aria da Capo e Fine', meaning 'play the Aria again and that's the end'. The Aria itself is not supplied again, which gives the pianist the curious sensation of turning back to the beginning and starting all over again. Does the Aria sound different because of all that we have heard? In a way it doesn't, or at least not to me; it feels more like some kind of supporting pillar being placed at the end of the design.

Chapter Title: Italian Concerto, BWV 971

Chapter Author(s): BACH

Book Title: The Piano

Book Subtitle: A History in 100 Pieces

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Published by: Yale University Press. (2021)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv1t1kfj8.6>

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2. *Italian Concerto*, BWV 971

There are many Bach keyboard works one could explore, but for contrast, here is one which shows him in ebullient, outward-looking mood: the *Italian Concerto*, or more properly the *Concerto nach italiänischem Gusto* (Concerto according to Italian Taste). Bach was an admirer of the Italian *concerto grosso* style of Corelli and Vivaldi, where a soloist or soloists engage in musical debate with an orchestra in episodes which make great play with the contrast between solo and 'tutti' ('all', meaning the orchestra). Bach had transcribed a number of these Italian works for keyboard, taking advantage of the two-manual harpsichord to create the effect of 'soloist' and 'orchestra'.

Eventually Bach decided to write an 'Italian concerto' of his own. He included it in the second part of his *Clavierübung* (Keyboard Practice), a collection of works which came out in 1735. Clearly he wanted to dispel any notion that he was just a provincial Kapellmeister (director of music), for he includes not only this Italian concerto but also a French overture, both evidence of a cosmopolitan outlook. The *Italian Concerto* was an immediate success and even the hard-to-please critic Johann Adolf Scheibe, who had previously complained that Bach's style of writing was 'heavy and sophisticated', changed his mind and decreed that the *Italian Concerto* was 'a perfect model of a well-designed concerto . . . Mr Bach has taken almost single-handed possession of the clavier.'

The concerto is an example of Bach trying his hand at the lighter, more melodic, 'galant' style of composition favoured by his sons Carl Philipp Emanuel and Johann Christian, who were composers too. The piece is notable for its good humour and high spirits. It is in three movements, two cheerful outer movements framing a glorious slow movement. Bach has written 'forte' and 'piano' over certain passages to tell the harpsichordist which bits to play on the lower (grander) manual and when to use the upper manual. On the modern piano, there is only one keyboard, so the harpsichord's built-in layers of sound must be imitated on the piano by the player's tone control and ability to vary the dynamic. When one attempts to follow Bach's 'forte' and 'piano' indications, however, one discovers that they are not the entire solution, because some passages could be imagined as

either 'orchestral' or 'solo' or both, and sometimes one hand appears to be 'the soloist' while the other is 'the accompaniment'. Moreover, sometimes the orchestra must be loud while the soloist is soft, and occasionally it is the other way round. This, after all, was written as a keyboard piece and not a collaboration between harpsichord and orchestra; we are in the realm of the imaginary, and with these fluid musical lines it is as well not to be dogmatic.

With the crisp articulation of the harpsichord, it is easier to convey the expressive meaning of the rests. Bach has a wonderful way of making his rests 'tell', and pianists should make an effort not to pedal through them or lazily hold down the keys too long so that the rests don't speak. For example, at the end of the first four-bar phrase, there is a one-beat rest. Played correctly, this rest contributes a rhythmical silence charged with excitement. The rest is almost as important as the notes themselves, and there are many other such examples. Clearing away the notes immediately their prescribed duration ends will allow other lines to come through, for example when the 'orchestra' enters with more rapid notes as the soloist is just finishing off a phrase. Bach doesn't give an overall tempo indication for the first movement, but the bars with especially rapid figuration (those with demisemiquaver movement) would suggest that the tempo should be steady enough to allow this fast decoration to register in all its sparkling precision without becoming gabbled.

Bach indicates 'Andante' for his D minor slow movement, which probably means he doesn't want it to be too slow ('andante' means 'moving along' in Italian). This is a marvellous structure wherein the bass follows a repeating rhythmical pattern throughout while the melody line weaves and embroiders a most beautiful design in the air above it. The movement divides more or less into two equal sections, the first half moving from D minor to F major, the second half starting again in D minor and, making some slight detours to other keys, winding its way back to a D minor close. In both halves, the lead-up to the final settling on a key is done by means of 'pedal notes' in the bass; that is, low notes which repeat in every bar and build up our expectation of what is going to happen harmonically. It is easy to imagine these low notes, in this case repeated quavers (C in the first half leading towards F major, A in the

second half leading towards D minor), being played 'pizzicato' on cellos or double basses.

Above the hypnotically steady rhythm of the bass, the right hand superimposes phrases of various lengths, entering after only three 'orchestral' bars and gradually extending its phrases, so that by the time the pedal notes enter in the bass, the melody is embarking on a very long phrase which goes all the way to the cadence. In the second half, the soloist continues to spin very long phrases, dipping and weaving without ever coming to rest until the cadence into D minor a few bars before the end. Although the melodic line may seem to have the character of an improvised embellishment, such as a gifted player might be able to undertake with some indication of the underlying harmonies (e.g. 'figured bass'), Bach goes to the trouble of writing out exactly what he wanted to hear, and indeed his line is so lovely that it is impossible to imagine an improvisation could match it. After we arrive back in D minor, five bars before the end, there is a little coda or tailpiece in which the soloist inflects the intricate melody line with some unexpected and poignant chromatic notes, another example of how Bach can make us feel that music is somehow gathering internal energy at the same time as it is drawing to a close.

If played as he wrote it, the final bar of the slow movement may seem shockingly abrupt, for Bach cuts off the music after only one beat, followed by two beats of silence. It takes nerve to do it, but is worth trying, because it illuminates the fact that the music ends as the architectural design is completed. A self-indulgent effect of lingering on the final notes, letting them ring 'sadly' on, is no part of his design.

The final Presto is an unstoppable display of great good humour as well as contrapuntal invention. It's composed almost entirely in running quavers and crotchets, and it moves mainly between F major and its most closely related keys, but gives the impression of having an inexhaustible fund of ideas about what to do next. The tempo should not be allowed to run away and get faster and faster, as often happens in performance, because the charm of this Presto is enhanced by its dance-like poise. The musical interest keeps swapping from one hand to the other, so that rather like one of Bach's two-part Inventions, there seems to be

good-natured competition between the hands to grab musical ideas from one another. Sometimes a third strand is introduced, so that for example the right hand plays both melody and descant, while the left hand marks out the crotchet beats (often marked 'forte') like jolly double-bass pizzicatos. There is not a single silent beat in the movement; each time a long phrase comes to an end in one voice, another voice rushes to fill the potential gap with a scale passage introducing the next motif. Bach had certainly mastered the vivacious 'Italian style' of Vivaldi and Corelli, almost outdoing them in wit and ingenuity.

3. Sonata for Violin and Harpsichord in E major, BWV 1016

Bach's sonatas for violin and harpsichord are not as well known as, say, his sonatas and partitas for unaccompanied violin, but they are at least as fine. Written during 1717–23 when Bach was employed at the court of Cöthen in Germany, they are amongst the first duo sonatas where the instruments are treated as equal partners. Before Bach's time it was the custom to have the violin part written out and the harpsichord part consisting only of a bass line with 'figures', that is, little numbers below the notes which told the keyboard player what chord to play above any given bass note, leaving the player to add any other tasteful elaborations which came to mind. In his sonatas for violin and harpsichord, Bach moved on from this custom; both parts are completely written out (apart from a few passages with 'figured bass'), a decision essential when the interplay of parts is so intricate.

Musically, Bach makes it absolutely clear that he regards the two players as equal. He treats the violin and the harpsichordist's right hand as conversational partners, swapping ideas and chasing one another through the movements. The harpsichordist's left hand generally plays the role of a viol or cello, laying out the bass line in steadier rhythms. In this sense, Bach's duo sonatas are modelled on the 'trio sonata' made famous by Corelli, where two treble instruments (violins, perhaps, or flutes or recorders) would take the starring roles while the bass line was played by a bass viol player or a cellist, with a harpsichord or organ duplicating that bass line and adding appropriate chords. (As there were four players

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involved, one might think that this would be more accurately called a 'sonata a quattro', but 'trio' refers to two melody parts plus a bass line.) But here Bach upgrades the keyboard part and gives it both solo and accompanying roles, so that the player is supplying two of the three roles in a 'trio sonata'.

A quarter of a century after J.S. Bach's death, C.P.E. Bach (a leading composer of the next generation) sent his father's six violin and harpsichord sonatas to Johann Forkel, who was preparing a biography of J.S. Bach. C.P.E. Bach said of the sonatas that 'they still sound very good, and give me a lot of pleasure, even though they're over fifty years old'. If fifty years seemed a long time to C.P.E. Bach, how astonished would he be to learn that three hundred years later they are still giving pleasure? Today one hears them played with violin and harpsichord and with a modern piano; each instrument brings out different facets of the music. In a larger hall it may be difficult to hear the harpsichord with clarity. On the other hand, its crisp articulation can bring life and air to dance-like movements especially. The modern piano with its superior sustaining sound is in some ways a better partner for the violin, but incautious use of the pedal can pour a thick sauce over tasty little details.

My favourite in this set of sonatas is no. 4 in E major, BWV 1016. It is a substantial four-movement work based on the Italian style of a slow movement, a fast movement, a slow movement and a fast finale. Right from the start one feels Bach's superb control of his musical ideas. The opening Adagio could have come from the *St Matthew Passion* or one of Bach's church cantatas. As the piano sets up a steady tread with repeating rhythmic motifs, the violin traces a rhapsodic line, subtly moving against the piano part in phrases of irregular length. In the bass of the piano part, a low octave E tolls through the first seven bars, building up tension until in bar 8 a shift of just a semitone feels like a major departure. Throughout the movement, the tension between the steady keyboard part and the virtuosic violin part is beautifully wrought, each part obviously needing the other, as though representing a parent walking stoically onward while a child joyfully runs rings around them.

The second movement brings a change of mood; the pianist bursts out with a cheeky tune which sounds almost like one of the folk songs Bach quotes in the

Goldberg Variations. As the violin enters with an echo of this tune (and the piano moves on to a counter-theme) it becomes clear that this is going to be an imitative movement, and not just between the violin and the pianist's right hand: the left hand is also drawn into the debate, leaving its bass line duties to become an active third partner in the back and forth. This is one of many movements where, employing only the most basic rhythms (mainly crotchets and quavers, and hardly a dotted note in sight), Bach finds it easy to weave together theme, counter-theme and other motifs in all kinds of ways which fit perfectly and never seem strained.

In the second slow movement, now in the more melancholy key of C sharp minor, the roles of soloist and accompanist are continually swapped between the two players (in contrast to the opening movement, where the roles are fixed). Again, there is beautiful balance between the simple 'walking' crotchets of the bass line in their four-bar units, the pulsing quaver chords (always with the first quaver of the bar missing) and the lilting triplets of the 'vocal' line, which passes from one instrument to the other. C.P.E. Bach had remarked to Forkel when sending him the sonatas that 'there are some Adagios here, which even today one could not compose in a more singing style'. C.P.E. Bach sometimes found his aged father's liking for complicated fugues a bit trying and preferred the graceful melodic style of his own era, so this is a compliment from him. As the movement progresses, the singing lines move against one another in canon, in opposite directions, and weaving around one another. Compared with the rhapsodic, virtuosic quality of the opening movement, however, this second slow movement is more like an intimate conversation between two people who know the value of expressing themselves with restraint.

The final Allegro is another feast of three-part imitative writing, the left hand liberated from the steady path it walked in the previous movement. Often it supplies punchy rhythmic motifs, but eventually it joins in with the chase as scurrying semiquavers are passed from one voice to another. The movement divides into three big parts: an opening section which recurs at the end, and in the middle a development that begins with a delightful shift into triplets on the violin, echoed by the piano. Triplet and semiquaver figures start to compete for attention, until

at the midpoint of the movement the triplets suddenly vanish, the lilt vanishes with them, and the rest is an energetic tussle between quavers and semiquavers. Most pianists will find it tricky to work out a good fingering for some of the rapid passages, and it would certainly be useful to have a sixth finger on each hand. We must remember, however, that our modern obsession with smooth legato fingering was not shared by the harpsichordists of Bach's time. In playing such fiddly passages, they probably jumped around the keys, lifting their hands as necessary rather than passing the thumb under. This is tricky in a different way, but can give a pleasant feeling of improvisation.

DOMENICO SCARLATTI (1685–1757)

4. Sonata in E major, K380, and an overview of other sonatas

Domenico Scarlatti, the son of opera composer Alessandro Scarlatti, was an Italian harpsichord composer of the Baroque era whose career also brought him into contact with the early piano. At first he followed in his father's footsteps, concentrating on vocal works, but the second half of his life brought him travel opportunities which changed his musical outlook.

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Book Title: The Piano

Book Subtitle: A History in 100 Pieces

Book Author(s): Susan Tomes

Published by: Yale University Press. (2021)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv1t1kfj8.8>

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at the midpoint of the movement the triplets suddenly vanish, the lilt vanishes with them, and the rest is an energetic tussle between quavers and semiquavers. Most pianists will find it tricky to work out a good fingering for some of the rapid passages, and it would certainly be useful to have a sixth finger on each hand. We must remember, however, that our modern obsession with smooth legato fingering was not shared by the harpsichordists of Bach's time. In playing such fiddly passages, they probably jumped around the keys, lifting their hands as necessary rather than passing the thumb under. This is tricky in a different way, but can give a pleasant feeling of improvisation.

DOMENICO SCARLATTI (1685–1757)

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Even when Ferdinand VI succeeded his father, the gloomy atmosphere of the court was not entirely dispelled, because the new king had inherited his father's

tendency to depression. Queen Maria Barbara often asked Scarlatti to come and improvise for her on the harpsichord and it is not difficult to imagine how earnestly Scarlatti must have wished to cheer her up and distract her. The queen possessed a number of keyboard instruments including a fortepiano; we don't know how much notice Scarlatti took of the piano, but he would certainly have tried it and might well have envisaged some of his sonatas being played on it. Scarlatti was also a card player who liked to gamble. In his sixties he ran up gambling debts which, allegedly, the queen offered to pay off in exchange for some written-out copies of the keyboard sonatas she had so much enjoyed. Whether or not this is strictly true, we know that this was the golden era of Scarlatti's keyboard writing.

When Scarlatti moved to Spain he spent the first few years based at the Alcázar palace in Seville, surrounded by magnificent Moorish decorations whose colour and detail found echoes in his music. He must also have heard the popular music of Spain with its Moorish, flamenco and gypsy influences, and its guitars, mandolins, castanets and drums. Such music often uses a mode, or type of scale, known as the Phrygian mode; we can find it by starting on the note E on a keyboard and playing all the white notes up to the next E. Several of the notes may seem exotically sour to ears accustomed to the traditional major scale (C to C on the white notes). In particular, the second note of the Phrygian mode (if starting on the note E, this second note would be F) has a 'flattened' sound which Scarlatti sometimes combined with an E major chord to add spice to the chord, a device used to this day by flamenco guitarists.

Scarlatti's use of this mode gave his music a piquant flavour which set it apart from the music of his exact contemporaries Bach and Handel (all three great composers were born in 1685). In fact, most of Scarlatti's sonatas were not published or known until long after his death. They found a wider audience only in the mid-nineteenth century when Clara Schumann and Liszt began including some Scarlatti in their recital programmes, but it was only really in the twentieth century that they became part of standard piano repertoire. In 1906 the Neapolitan pianist Alessandro Longo published the first complete edition of the sonatas in a numbering system of his own devising, and in 1953 the American historian and

harpichordist Ralph Kirkpatrick published a chronological catalogue, whose K numbers are now the standard way of identifying the sonatas. To a modern reader, 'sonata' may suggest a longer work, but Scarlatti used it simply to mean an instrumental piece, something played (or 'sounded') rather than sung. Most of his sonatas take no more than a minute or two to play.

Scarlatti favoured lively tempos, and many of his sonatas are little nuggets of vivacity. They are generally in two halves, structured like the dance movements of a Baroque suite: the first half moves to the dominant key (say, from C major to G major) and the second half, musing on the same musical material, works its way back to the home key. Within this simple formula Scarlatti produced a huge variety of moods: lively, melancholy, manic, graceful, exuberant and thoughtful. He skilfully deploys bittersweet flavourings with the result that many of his major-key sonatas have a vein of melancholy running through them, while many of his minor-key pieces vibrate with alertness. The physical pleasure of darting about the keys, using the fingers with jeweller-like precision to put a sparkle on the musical surface, communicates itself vividly to the player.

In piano competitions, I have often heard Scarlatti sonatas played at top speed to show off rapid fingerwork, but to rattle them off in this way is to lose their savour. It may be true that some of them were designed to be played in settings where aristocratic guests could lend only an occasional ear to the music; perhaps as a result Scarlatti allowed his own facility at the keyboard to steer his compositions, but he always took care to sculpt their pleasing surface into delicate loops and curves. Moreover, the player who takes Scarlatti for granted may find that they trip over his elegantly contrived distortions of expected phrase lengths.

The 'ping' of the harpsichord's plectrum on the string is very different from the sound of a piano's felt hammer. When we play Scarlatti on the modern piano, should we imagine that we are playing a harpsichord, or should we rejoice that the piano offers more dynamic possibilities? As usual, different instruments bring out different qualities and offer different advantages. Many of his delicate effects are best appreciated on the older instrument whose plucking mechanism could be used to create delicious scrunches on chords and glittering, silvery scale passages, reminiscent of Spanish guitar technique (e.g. the Sonata in D major, K492, or the

Sonata in C minor, K56). Scarlatti often writes in a fluent two-part style, left and right hand working in lively counterpoint (for example, the Sonata in D minor, K1), but he frequently incorporates passages of 'Iberian' or 'Moorish'-sounding music where important notes are decorated with rapid ornaments such as a flamenco singer might use to emphasise a word (e.g. the Sonata in G minor, K426). I'm fond of the wistful Sonata in B flat, K273, a two-part design where a lilting dance in 3/8 time gives way to a plaintive 'jig' whose melodic figures, repeated over slowly shifting Spanish-guitar-flavoured chords in the bass, are hypnotic.

Scarlatti often seems to think in terms of contrasts between solo and tutti passages, as though imagining how he might orchestrate the piece (e.g. the 'fanfares' and 'mandolins' of the Sonata in D major, K96). He frequently uses fast repeating notes (e.g. the Sonata in A major, K24, the G major, K455, or the D minor, K141), a glittering effect on the harpsichord but one which can seem strenuous on the heavier mechanism of the modern piano. In earlier sonatas he makes gleeful use of hand-crossing (such as the Sonata in B minor, K27), but in later years, when he became stout and no longer found it easy to cross his hands in front of him at the keyboard, this effect is quietly dropped. In rapid passage-work he often makes the hands compete for space on the same key, for example in the Sonata in F major, K17, or the Sonata in A major, K24. Sometimes he just delights in making the hands chase one another about the keyboard, for example in the exuberant Sonata in E major, K20.

Some of his slower, more cantabile sonatas make one feel he might have improvised them on the piano; the Sonata in D minor, K9, the Sonata in G minor, K8, and the languorous Sonata in A major, K208, all share a pensive mood well suited to the piano. A particular favourite of mine is the Sonata in E major, K380, which seems to evoke a royal person proceeding in stately but good-humoured fashion down the palace corridor to the sound of distant fanfares. Repeated notes and chords are a feature of the sonata, but somehow Scarlatti's use of them suggests buoyancy and poise rather than lack of invention, and their cumulative effect can be quietly mesmerising. Wanda Landowska, recording Scarlatti in Paris in the 1930s, used all the resources of her modern Pleyel harpsichord to evoke a procession

coming towards us and passing on into the distance, a version which made the Sonata in E major famous and attracted the attention of pianists, who by contrast have tended to adopt a more delicate, tender approach when they play it on the piano. Altogether Scarlatti wrote 555 keyboard sonatas, so there is plenty to explore.

CARL PHILIPP EMANUEL BACH (1714–1788)

5. *Freie Fantasie* in F sharp minor, Wq.67, H.300

C.P.E. Bach was the second surviving son of J.S. Bach and his first wife Maria Barbara. Today we tend to think of C.P.E. (known as Emanuel) Bach as less important than his famous father, so it comes as a shock to learn that in the second half of the eighteenth century it was C.P.E. Bach who was the better known. Mozart once said that ‘Bach is the father – we are the boys!’ People coming across this quote might naturally assume Mozart was talking about the great Johann Sebastian, but in fact the Bach he was referring to was Emanuel, whose work was highly esteemed by Haydn and Beethoven as well as Mozart himself. Fifty years later, their reputations changed place once more. Mendelssohn and his generation revived the works of J.S. Bach, who has never looked back, and Emanuel Bach moved to a quieter place in history’s estimation.

Emanuel Bach ‘had no other teacher than my father’ and his first pieces were in the style favoured by J.S. Bach. However, Emanuel lived at a time when taste was changing. Italian opera was becoming popular in Germany and would soon be all the rage. The complexity and formality of late eighteenth-century music was being gradually replaced by a new ‘galant’ style characterised by its elegance, simplicity and immediate appeal. The religious feeling which inspired J.S. Bach’s music was not the driving force for his son – Emanuel Bach grew up at a time when secular values were becoming more important, and he engaged with scholars and philosophers of the German Enlightenment. Musicians were starting to feel that instead of (or as well as) directing their performances in the service of God, they could aim to communicate directly with listeners, letting audiences understand and share their musical emotions.

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Emanuel Bach was appointed court harpsichordist to Frederick the Great in Berlin. Emanuel himself preferred the clavichord with its greater range of delicate expression, but he was an excellent harpsichordist too. The king was a keen flute player who liked to play chamber music in the evenings. Emanuel, who shared his job with another harpsichordist, was only required on alternate months, so he had plenty of time for composing and teaching. During his years in Berlin he wrote an extremely influential treatise on *The True Art of Playing Keyboard Instruments* (1753), which is still an important source for students of historical style. At the time, the use of the thumb when playing was not common; it was used when the pattern of notes made it the only obvious choice, but most passages were played with fingers 2, 3, 4 and 5. Emanuel advocates the method of ‘passing the thumb under’ to extend the hand’s range.

He also talks about the importance of the musician feeling the emotions of the music. ‘Since a musician cannot move others unless he himself is moved, he must of necessity feel all the emotions he hopes to arouse in his listeners.’ Emanuel also talks about the importance of being able to improvise, commenting that nothing is a better indication of a musician’s potential for composing. Improvisation was not new, of course, but what was new was the sense that when improvising, a musician was deliberately letting us in on a stream of consciousness, aiming to show us not just how their mind was working but also how they were feeling. From this standpoint it’s easy to see that not many steps were required to get to the powerfully ‘personal’ utterances of Haydn, Mozart and Beethoven.

Emanuel Bach wrote large numbers of keyboard works – principally sonatas and concertos, but also fantasies in which he could give free rein to whatever thoughts and feelings were occurring to him. In the short autobiography he wrote in the 1770s, he says that among his keyboard works there are ‘only a few that I composed in complete freedom and for my own use.’ One of the most remarkable is the *Freie Fantasie* (Free Fantasy) in F sharp minor which he wrote in 1787, the year before he died. In a way it resembles the sort of writing in J.S. Bach’s *Chromatic Fantasy and Fugue*, but Emanuel makes a point of unpredictable and startling changes of key, mood and volume which his father would probably have considered unfocused. Even the Free Fantasy’s appearance is interesting – there are long

passages where the duration of notes is indicated but without bar lines, leaving the player to decide where the music needs to ‘breathe’.

There are several recurring themes – a solemn, slow opening Adagio passage; an Allegretto featuring virtuoso flourishes; and a lyrical Largo in 12/8 which appears in several different keys and also brings the piece to a close. This Largo theme may be a private tribute to his father, for in its first bar it incorporates the melodic motif that J.S. Bach used to represent his own name (BACH in German music notation is our B flat, A, C, B natural, here transposed into the key of B minor) and in the second bar it quotes from J.S. Bach’s aria ‘Es ist vollbracht’ (It is fulfilled) from the *St John Passion*.

Between these helpfully recurring themes, we pass through uncharted territory as Emanuel veers from one key to another, constantly changing volume levels and moods, letting his musical lines twist and turn as though searching vainly for a place to rest and interrupting their progress with sharply snatched chords like exclamation points. Sometimes it feels as if he is writing the kind of dramatic ‘recitative’ of which his father was such a master, where a singer tells us something in rhythms closer to speech than to singing. Towards the end, Emanuel seems to be getting more and more worked up, but he interrupts himself with a final quote from his Largo/J.S. Bach theme, as if sighting home from a choppy sea.

This intriguing piece gives us a chance to experience for ourselves the way in which Emanuel Bach improvised at a time when ‘expressing yourself’ started to be fashionable. The English writer Charles Burney, who travelled through Germany in 1772 to collect his impressions of musical life on the continent, was keen to meet C.P.E. Bach, whom he regarded as ‘not only one of the greatest composers who ever existed, for the keyboard, but the best player, in point of *expression* ... He is learned, I think, even beyond his father’. One night after dinner, Burney had the chance to hear C.P.E. Bach improvising for several hours. ‘During this time he grew so animated and possessed, that he not only played but looked like one inspired. His eyes were fixed, his under lip fell, and drops of effervescence fell from his countenance.’ Clearly this was no mere improvising to entertain the dinner guests; Emanuel Bach had a powerful desire to communicate his inner feelings, and luckily Burney was listening.

